

A. A credit freeze is a relatively new way to add another layer of protection to your credit report. While a fraud alert notifies lenders that your identity has been stolen, a freeze simply restricts all access to your report. To put a freeze on your credit, go to the appropriate link on each of the credit bureaus' websites and submit a written request. After the freeze is activated (which can take anywhere from fifteen minutes to three days and costs about \$10), companies that you already do business with will still have access to your credit report, but no new third parties, including potential lenders, can get a copy. You can temporarily lift the freeze if you need to apply for new credit, but it could take a few days.

Q: I'm married. Does that mean my spouse and I have the same credit report?

A: No. If you have a joint credit card or loan, this account will be noted on both your individual credit reports. Keep in mind that whenever you share a card or cosign a loan, you're liable for each other's debts. It's important for you to keep at least one loan or credit card in your own name and for your spouse to do the same, so that each of you establishes a separate credit history. If you don't, you'll have trouble getting credit if you get divorced or if your spouse dies.

Q: Who can look at my credit report?

A: The law says that credit bureaus can disclose information about you to any person or organization with a "permissible purpose" for seeing the information. That can include a lender, an insurance company, a landlord who wants to find out about your past financial habits, or even a potential employer who wants to know more about you. (Potential employers, unlike lenders or landlords, must get your written permission before requesting your credit history.) A copy of your report will show who has made inquiries about you in the past two years.

THE \$51,000 LATE PAYMENT